

# Sports

## Splashes

By MARTY COHEN  
Sun-Tattler Sports Editor

### Can Still Throw Straight At 63



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The dark-skinned blackfoot Indian smiled as a host of kids chased a foul ball.

It was Indianapolis against Buffalo at Dowdy field.

The biggest of the kids brought the baseball to the 63-year-old veteran city employee.

"Can I throw back to the players?" the youngster asked.

Jacques LaMarr smiled kindly. "Let me try this one," he said, as he took the ball and winged it straight into a coach's hands. "My arm is as strong as ever," he said.

It was in 1928 that the well-educated LaMaar was given a job as Dowdy field groundkeeper. "They put me on a week's probation. I've been here ever since," he said.

LaMarr, known as a second father to hundreds of South Broward youngsters, has watched the decline of softball in Hollywood with a sorrowful eye. He remembers when a national champion softball team playing out of Dowdy field drew crowds of 2,000 to 3,000.

The Hollywood team won the national crown in 1933 and went to Cuba where they whipped a famous Havana team in an 11-game series.

"Softball was just starting then. Fort Lauderdale, North Miami, Miami Beach, and Hollywood had boys' and girls' teams and the competition was great," he said.

LaMarr said there are too many softball games here during the summer. "Five nights a week the men play at Dowdy field," he said. "The same teams and the same players night after night can't draw any crowds."

The veteran groundkeeper doesn't think Hollywood is a baseball town. Several minor league teams tried to play with Dowdy as home base but failed to make the grade, LaMarr said.

A new stadium in a central location with adequate parking could make the game go, LaMarr said.

After the softball team folded in 1934, Burt Shotton brought his Columbus Red Birds into Dowdy for spring training. The Baltimore Orioles made Dowdy their spring home for 10 years and the White Sox farm teams followed.

LaMarr calls Dowdy field in its best condition this season. "We worked on it all summer and made many improvements," he said.

Indianapolis is drawing in early workouts better than any minor league team that ever trained here, the baseball-minded groundkeeper said.

LaMarr loves kids and knows hundreds by their first names. He sees fathers he watched play at Dowdy bring their youngsters for workouts.

However, LaMarr is concerned about rising vandalism at the park. It was worse last year than every before, he said.

"The kids, 12 and under, don't have any place to play or anything to do," LaMarr said. "They should let the youngsters use the softball field more in the summer instead of having so many adult teams."

LaMarr sees clinics like the Sun-Tattler's this Saturday as a big answer to the problem. "However, there's not enough of them," he said.

"God made heaven, had a little left over, and made Florida," the old-timer said.

Although he sounds like a walking chamber of commerce he means every word. "Even the climate is getting better. We don't get the cold spells we use to. They don't last as long and it doesn't get as cold," he said.

LaMarr came to Hollywood after working with Ringling Brothers circus for nine years. He studied recreation in three Missouri schools.

He helped cut the weeds and plant the first grass at Dowdy field.

LaMarr's son, a Korean veteran, is working at the Broward county courthouse in Fort Lauderdale, and attending the University of Miami law school.

If Andy Cohen, Indianapolis manager, plays it cool, he might get a new mascot for the Indians, LaMarr is raising an eight-inch pet alligator named Pete.

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